HTML Notes: Chapter 4 – Links

Links between pages, to other sites, email links

Basics

- Links are the defining feature of the web. They let you move from one page to another (browsing / surfing).
- Common types: from one website to another; from one page to another on the same site; from one part of a page to another part of the same page; links that open in a new window; links that start an email.

Writing links `<a>`

- Links use the `<a>` element. Users can click anything between the opening `<a>` and closing `</a>` tags.
- The `href` attribute says which page the link goes to.
- **Link text** = the text between the tags. It should explain where the user will go (not just "click here").
- Clear link text helps people who scan for links and people using screen readers.
- Think of words people would search for: "hotels in New York" is better than "places to stay".

HTML

```
<a href="http://www.imdb.com">IMDB</a>

-> href = page the link goes to
-> IMDB = text the user clicks
-> </a> = closing link tag
```

RESULT

IMDB

Linking to other sites

- Use `<a>` with an `href` whose value is the page you want people to go to.
- For a different website, the value is the full web address = an **absolute URL**.
- Browsers show links blue and underlined by default.
- **URL** = Uniform Resource Locator, the web address of a page. Every web page has its own.
- An absolute URL starts with the domain name and can be followed by the path to a specific page. If no page is given, the site shows its homepage.

HTML

```
<p>Movie Reviews:
  <ul>
    <li><a href="http://www.
      empireonline.com">
      Empire</a></li>
    <li><a href="http://www.
      metacritic.com">
      Metacritic</a></li>
    <li><a href="http://www.
      variety.com">
      Variety</a></li>
  </ul>
</p>
```

RESULT

Movie Reviews:

- Empire
- Metacritic
- Variety

Linking to pages on the same site

- No need for the domain name. Use a shorthand called a **relative URL**.
- If all pages are in the same folder, the `href` is just the file name.
- If pages are in different folders, you need slightly more complex syntax showing where the page is in relation to the current page (see Relative URLs below).
- Relative URLs are handy when building a site on your own computer because you can link pages without a domain name or hosting. They are also quicker to write.

HTML

```
<ul>
  <li><a href="index.html">
    Home</a></li>
  <li><a href="about-us.html">
    About</a></li>
  <li><a href="movies.html">
    Movies</a></li>
  <li><a href="contact.html">
    Contact</a></li>
</ul>
```

RESULT

- Home
- About
- Movies
- Contact

Directory structure

- On bigger sites, put the pages for each section in its own folder. Folders are also called **directories**.
- The top-level folder is the **root** folder (here: examplearts). It holds all other files and folders.
- Relationships use family tree words: examplearts is the **parent** of movies, music and theater (they are its **children**). examplearts is the **grandparent** of the dvd folder (dvd is a **grandchild**).
- The main homepage (and each section's homepage) is called **index.html**. Servers return it if no file name is given: examplearts.com gives examplearts.com/index.html, and examplearts.com/music gives .../music/index.html.
- Every page and image has a URL = domain name + **path**. E.g. www.examplearts.com/index.html and examplearts.com/images/logo.gif.
- CMS, blogging and e-commerce systems often use one template file per type of page (news, blog posts, products). Editing the template changes all pages using it. Don't change non-HTML code or you may break the page.

EXAMPLE SITE

```
examplearts/
  index.html
  images/
    logo.gif
  movies/
    cinema/
      index.html
      listings.html
      reviews.html
    dvd/
      index.html
      reviews.html
  music/
    index.html
    listings.html
    reviews.html
  theater/
    index.html
    listings.html
    reviews.html
```

Relative URLs

- Shorthand way of telling the browser where a page is *in relation to the current page*.
- **Same folder**: just use the file name.
- **Child folder**: folder name + / + file name.
- **Grandchild folder**: child folder / grandchild folder / file name.
- **Parent folder**: use `../` to go up one folder, then the file name.
- **Grandparent folder**: repeat `../` to go up two folders.
- Linking to the same page from two different pages may need two different relative URLs.
- On a live server: a child folder name with no file usually shows that section's homepage. A forward slash alone returns the whole site's homepage; a slash plus file name returns that file if it's in the root directory. These don't work on your local computer.

LINK TYPES (from the example site)

```
Same folder:
  <a href="reviews.html">Reviews</a>
  (music reviews from music homepage)

Child folder:
  <a href="music/listings.html">
  Listings</a>
  (music listings from homepage)

Grandchild folder:
  <a href="movies/dvd/reviews.html">
  Reviews</a>
  (DVD reviews from homepage)

Parent folder:
  <a href="../index.html">Home</a>
  (homepage from music reviews)

Grandparent folder:
  <a href="../../index.html">
  Home</a>
  (homepage from DVD reviews)
```

Email links `mailto:`

- Use `<a>` but start the `href` value with `mailto:` followed by the email address.
- It looks like any other link, but clicking it opens the user's email program with a new message addressed to that person.

HTML

```
<a href="mailto:jon@example.org">
  Email Jon</a>
```

RESULT

Email Jon

[clicking opens a New Message with To: jon@example.org]

Opening links in a new window `target`

- Add the `target` attribute to the opening `<a>` tag with the value `_blank`.
- Common reason: the link points to another website and you hope the user returns to your site afterwards.
- Generally avoid it. If you do use it, tell users beforehand that it opens a new window.

HTML

```
<a href="http://www.imdb.com"
  target="_blank">
  Internet Movie Database</a>
  (opens in new window)
```

RESULT

Internet Movie Database (opens in new window)

Linking to a specific part of the same page

- Useful for a table of contents at the top of a long page, or a "Top" link at the bottom.
- Step 1: mark the target with the `id` attribute (works on every HTML element).
- The id value must start with a letter or underscore (not a number or other character). No two ids on one page can have the same value.
- Step 2: link with `<a>` where `href` starts with # followed by the id value.
- E.g. `<a href="#top">` links to the `<h1>` with id="top".

HTML

```
<h1 id="top">Film-Making Terms</h1>
<a href="#arc_shot">Arc Shot</a><br />
<a href="#interlude">Interlude</a><br />
<a href="#prologue">Prologue</a>
<h2 id="arc_shot">Arc Shot</h2>
<p>A shot in which...</p>
<h2 id="interlude">Interlude</h2>
<p>A brief, intervening...</p>
<h2 id="prologue">Prologue</h2>
<p>A speech, preface...</p>
<p><a href="#top">Top</a></p>
```

RESULT

Film-Making Terms

Arc Shot

Interlude

Prologue

Arc Shot

A shot in which...

Interlude

A brief, intervening...

Prologue

A speech, preface...

Top (jumps back to the h1)

Linking to a specific part of another page

- Same technique: the target page needs **id** attributes on the parts you want.
- Add # + the id value to the end of the page's address.
- `href` = address of page (absolute or relative URL) + # + id value.
- Example: link to the bottom of the book's website homepage.

HTML

```
<a href="http://www.
  htmlandcssbook.com/#bottom">

(relative version)
<a href="movies.html#reviews">
```

Quick cheat sheet

Tag / attribute	Use
`<a href="...">`	Create a link (href = where it goes)
`absolute URL`	Full address, e.g. http://www.imdb.com
`relative URL`	Shorthand for pages on your own site
`../`	Go up one folder (repeat for more)
`index.html`	Homepage of a site or section
`mailto:`	Email link, e.g. mailto:jon@example.org
`target="_blank"`	Open link in a new window
`id="name"`	Mark a part of a page
`href="#name"`	Link to a part of the same page
`page.html#name`	Link to a part of another page